Raise the bar.

Research on leadership points to four things that make a team more ambitious, and one warning about using them too hard. This dossier gives you the evidence, the sentences and the grammar to talk about it.

NAME _____ DATE _____

This is your page for the lesson. The numbers and titles match the lesson on the screen. Write on the lines, circle your answer. **Bold on grey** is a chunk to learn. Dotted is a word to look up. The Portuguese for these words is on the last pages.

1 WARM UP

Where do you stand?

Before you read anything, tell us what you think. Circle the answer closest to your opinion. There is no right answer.

A good leader sets targets that feel a little uncomfortable.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

Telling people to "do your best" works as well as giving them a number.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A team that feels safe works less hard.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A leader who expects more usually gets more.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

How close is your guess?

Two numbers from the dossier. Write your guess.

Google asks teams to set very ambitious goals. Then it gives each goal a score from 0% to 100%. The score shows how much of the goal the team reached. At what average score does Google say the sweet spot starts?

A perfect score is not the goal.

My guess _____ %

Some teams are very engaged and some are not. According to Gallup, what percentage of this difference between teams comes from the manager?

Engagement means how much people care about their work.

My guess _____ %

Talk about these first

Then read the article and see who agrees with you.

1 Think of a boss, teacher or coach who made you try something you thought was too hard. What did that person do?

_____

2 Has someone ever given you a target that felt impossible? What happened?

---

3 Who should set a team's targets: the leader, the team, or both? Why?

---

4 Your manager says: "We need to be more ambitious." What do you want to hear next? What do you not want to hear?

---

5 Can a team be too ambitious? How would you know?

---

2 ARTICLE

LEADERSHIP · TEAMS

Four levers and one warning

A leader cannot make a team ambitious just by asking for more. Research points to four things leaders do, and one way to go too far.

By EIC Magazine · 5 min read

Almost every manager says, "I want an ambitious team." Fewer managers ask what they should do to build one. That matters: Gallup says about 70% of the **difference** in team **engagement** comes from the manager. Research on goals, expectations and teamwork points to four **levers**: meaning, belief, targets and safety. It also gives a warning: a **stretch goal** can hurt a team if the leader uses it in the wrong way.

MEANING

People work harder for a goal they believe in. Edwin Locke and Gary Latham reviewed 35 years of research on goal setting. They found that **commitment** grows when leaders communicate an inspiring vision and **behave supportively**. A 2004 analysis of 87 sources found that **transformational leadership** was linked to better **outcomes**. In this style, the leader inspires people around a vision. **Hands-off** leadership was linked to worse results. In 2025, Adam Galinsky wrote in Harvard Business Review that inspiring leaders play three roles: visionary, **exemplar** and mentor. The mentor challenges people to become the best version of themselves.

BELIEF

What a leader expects often becomes what a team **delivers**. This is called the **Pygmalion effect**. In 2000, D. Brian McNatt reviewed 17 studies with 2,874 people. On average, managers' expectations had a strong effect on performance. But the effect **varied** a lot from one setting to another. A classic Harvard Business Review article by J. Sterling Livingston gives managers a short piece of advice: expect the best. In practice, that means you expect people to reach a high standard, and you say so.

TARGETS

Belief is not enough. A team also needs a clear target. Locke and Latham found that people **consistently** performed better with specific, difficult goals than when they were only told to **do their best**. The effect is strongest when people are committed to the goal. People also need **feedback** on their progress. Google asks teams to set goals that "may feel **somewhat** uncomfortable." Then it gives each goal a score. The score shows how much of the goal the team reached: 100% is all of it. An average score of 60 to 70 percent is the **sweet spot**. A higher score may mean the goal was not high enough. Joseph Folkman says the best leaders use both pull and push. They give people a say and inspire them, and they also hold people accountable.

SAFETY

A hard goal means people may fail. In Google's study of 180 teams, the first of five **dynamics** was **psychological safety**. Amy Edmondson defines it as "a shared belief held by members of a team that the team is safe for **interpersonal risk taking**." On a safe team, a person can say "I am stuck" or "this will not work" without fear.

Progress also matters. Teresa Amabile and Steven Kramer wrote in Harvard Business Review that making progress in **meaningful** work does more for a positive inner work life than anything else they **examined**. Their advice to managers: help people take a step forward every day.

THE WARNING

Stretch goals can also fail. In "The Stretch Goal Paradox" (Harvard Business Review, 2017), Sim Sitkin, Chet Miller and Kelly See wrote that companies in trouble often use stretch goals in **a desperate attempt** to turn things around. They nearly always fail. The companies that could gain the most are those with recent wins and **spare resources**. They **rarely** use stretch goals. Another review, "Goals Gone Wild," listed the **side effects** of too many goals: unethical behavior, too much focus on one area, a **damaged** culture and lower **intrinsic motivation**. Its authors say leaders should use goals in doses, not as a **standard remedy**. A 2025 study of **early-career** engineers adds a question of fairness: **stretch assignments** did not **benefit** every group **equally**.

So the question for every leader is the same: what are you asking the team to do, and what will you do when the team falls short?

"We choose to go to the Moon in this decade and do the other things, not because they are easy, but because they are hard."

John F. Kennedy, Rice University, 12 September 1962

35 years
Research on goal setting, reviewed by Locke and Latham (2002)

180 teams
Studied by Google: psychological safety came first of five dynamics

60 to 70%
Google's sweet spot for the average score of ambitious objectives

About 70%
Share of the difference in engagement between teams that comes from the manager, according to Gallup

Sources: Locke and Latham, Building a practically useful theory of goal setting and task motivation, American Psychologist (2002); Judge and Piccolo, Journal of Applied Psychology (2004); McNatt, Journal of Applied Psychology (2000); Livingston, Pygmalion in Management, Harvard Business Review Classic; Galinsky, What Sets Inspirational Leaders Apart, Harvard Business Review (March and April 2025); Folkman, Harvard Business Review (24 May 2022); Amabile and Kramer, The Power of Small Wins, Harvard Business Review (May 2011); Sitkin, Miller and See, The Stretch Goal Paradox, Harvard Business Review (January and February 2017); Ordóñez, Schweitzer, Galinsky and Bazerman, Goals Gone Wild, Academy of Management Perspectives; Gilmartin and others, Harvard Business Review (28 May 2025); Google re:Work, Understand team effectiveness and Set goals with OKRs; Gallup, How Managers Impact Team Productivity (2026); John F. Kennedy Presidential Library.

Comments

7 readers · fictional voices for this lesson

Renata M. · São Paulo · operations manager
My director asked us to **double** the target in one quarter. Nobody explained why. We reached 60%, and everybody felt like a failure. Maybe the score was fine, but nobody told us.

Carlos T. · Campinas · sales director
Soft words do not move numbers. People need a clear target and a date. I hold people accountable every Monday, and my team respects that.

Dona Lúcia · Curitiba · retired plant manager
My first boss expected more from me than I expected from myself. I hated it for a year. Then I understood that she believed in me before I did.

Felipe · Recife · junior developer
I like hard goals. But I need to know that I can say "this will not work" without being punished. Last year I could not, and we learned about the problem too late.

Marcos · Belo Horizonte · HR business partner
We now ask each team to propose its own target first. Then we discuss it together. The teams asked for more than we would have asked.

Júlia · Lisbon · team lead
One thing is missing from the article: stretch for whom? In my team, the same two people always get the big projects, and the same two people get the credit.

Diego · Porto Alegre · startup founder
We are in trouble, so we set a huge goal for next quarter. After reading this, I think the article is about us.

Words from the article

Hover on the screen, or look here.

a desperate attempt
uma tentativa desesperada

a failure
um fracasso

be linked to
estar associado a

behave
agir, comportar-se

benefit
beneficiar-se, ganhar com

challenge people to
desafiar as pessoas a

commitment
comprometimento (com a meta)

communicate an inspiring vision
comunicar uma visão inspiradora

consistently
de forma consistente, quase sempre

credit
crédito, reconhecimento

damaged
prejudicado, danificado

deliver
entregar (resultados)

do your best
faça o seu melhor

double
dobrar

dynamics
dinâmicas, fatores (de equipe)

early-career
no início da carreira

engagement
engajamento

equally
igualmente, na mesma medida

examine
examinar, analisar

exemplar
exemplo, modelo a ser seguido

expect people to
esperar que as pessoas

feedback
retorno, feedback

from one setting to another
de um contexto para outro

hands-off
que deixa solto, sem orientação

have a say
ter voz na decisão

hold people accountable
cobrar resultados, responsabilizar as pessoas

I am stuck
estou travado, não consigo avançar

in doses
em doses, aos poucos

in trouble
em apuros, em dificuldade

inner work life
vida interior no trabalho (emoções e percepções)

interpersonal risk taking
correr riscos nas relações com os outros (discordar, admitir um erro)

intrinsic motivation
motivação intrínseca

lever
alavanca

meaningful
significativo, que tem sentido

outcome
resultado

point to
apontar para, indicar

psychological safety
segurança psicológica

pull and push
puxar e empurrar (inspirar e cobrar)

Pygmalion effect
efeito Pigmalião

rarely
raramente

side effects
efeitos colaterais

soft words do not move numbers
palavras brandas, sozinhas, não geram resultado

somewhat
um pouco, de certa forma

spare resources
recursos sobrando

standard remedy
remédio padrão, a mesma solução para tudo

stretch assignment
tarefa desafiadora para desenvolver a pessoa

stretch for whom
desafio para quem?

stretch goal
meta desafiadora, acima do que parece possível

supportively
de forma que dá apoio

sweet spot
ponto ideal, faixa ideal

take a step forward
dar um passo à frente

the best version of themselves
a melhor versão de si mesmos

transformational leadership
liderança transformacional

turn things around
reverter uma situação ruim

variance
variação, diferença entre equipes

vary
variar

More words from the exercises

The same chunks and phrases, from sections 3 to 9.

a big jump
um salto grande

a stretch
um desafio acima do normal

accountability
responsabilização, prestação de contas

add people
aumentar a equipe

be paid to
ser pago para

blame
culpar

buy-in
adesão, apoio

complain
reclamar

count as
valer como, ser considerado

cut
reduzir

excuse
desculpa, justificativa

failure is not an option
fracassar não é uma opção

fair point
boa colocação

fall behind
ficar para trás, atrasar

get it done
terminar a tarefa, fazer acontecer

here is why this matters
eis por que isso importa

hit the number
bater a meta

I hear you
entendo o que você diz

I see your point, but
entendo seu ponto, mas

it's on you
a responsabilidade é sua

I'd like us to
eu gostaria que a gente

lazy
preguiçoso

let's review it in four weeks
vamos revisar em quatro semanas

milestone
marco, etapa

miss
não atingir (a meta)

miss by
ficar abaixo da meta por (tanto)

own
ser responsável por

prescribe
prescrever

push
se esforçar, ir além

push back
discordar, questionar

raise the bar
elevar o padrão

rank
ficar em (primeiro, segundo...) lugar

rate
avaliar

review
revisão (de estudos), análise de vários estudos

separate
distinguir, separar

setting
contexto, ambiente

take something off your plate
tirar uma tarefa da sua lista

tell me early
me avise cedo

that may be true for
isso pode ser verdade para

what does the evidence say
o que as evidências dizem

what would it take
o que seria preciso

3 CHECK

What does the article say?

Facts first, then voices. Every answer is in the text or in the comments.

True or false?

Read the sentence. Is it true, according to the article? If it is false, write the correct fact on the line.

EXAMPLE "Google says a perfect score on an ambitious objective always means the team did very well."

False

It is false. Google says a higher score may mean the goals were not ambitious enough.

1 "Locke and Latham found that asking people to **do their best** works better than a specific, difficult goal."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

2 "Google treats an average score of 60 to 70 percent on ambitious objectives as a **sweet spot**."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

3 "In Google's study of 180 teams, **psychological safety** came first of five dynamics."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

4 "According to the Harvard Business Review article on stretch goals, companies in trouble usually succeed when they adopt them."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

5 "A 2025 study of **early-career** engineers found that **stretch assignments** benefited every group equally."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

6 "A classic Harvard Business Review article gives managers a short piece of advice: expect the best."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact.

Find the reader

All the answers are in the comments, below the article. Read them again and choose the name.

EXAMPLE Who says a clear target and a date matter more than soft words?

Carlos

Carlos says soft words do not move numbers. People need a clear target and a date.

1 Who says the team reached 60% and felt like a failure?

○ Felipe ○ Renata ○ Diego

2 Who says a tough boss was hard at first and useful later?

○ Dona Lúcia ○ Marcos ○ Júlia

3 Who says he needs to be able to say "this will not work" without being punished?

○ Carlos ○ Renata ○ Felipe

4 Who says the same two people always get the big projects?

○ Júlia ○ Diego ○ Dona Lúcia

4 CHUNKS

Chunks and patterns

Leaders repeat the same phrases. Learn the whole phrase and the pattern that goes with it, and the sentence builds itself.

Three families you already know

Three of the phrases below are verb patterns. The first verb decides what comes next, and these are the same Families 1, 2 and 3 from the Verb Patterns lesson.

FAMILY	THE PATTERN	THE VERBS	EXAMPLE
1	**verb + person + to + verb**	ask · expect · challenge · encourage · invite · trust · push · remind · want · need · would like	"We encourage people to speak up."

2	**let · make · have + person + verb**	Only three verbs. No to after the person.	“Let the team decide the deadline.”
3	**suggest · recommend · propose · insist + that + person + verb**	Formal. The verb stays in the base form: that he go, that they meet.	“I propose that we meet every Monday.”

Where the not goes

FAMILY	WHERE THE NOT GOES	EXAMPLE
1	**Two places**	“I didn’t ask them to start.” × “I asked them not to start.”
2	**The first verb**	“I didn’t let them start.” Never “I let them not start.”
3	**After that**	“I suggest that they not start.” Never “that they don’t start.”

Chunks you will need

Read each chunk inside a full sentence. Say it out loud once. You need these in the exercises below.

stretch goal n.	*“Let’s treat this as a stretch goal: 70% will count as a strong result.”* A goal set just beyond what seems possible. meta desafiadora
buy-in n.	*“I want your buy-in before I take this to the director.”* Agreement and support from the people who must do the work. adesão, apoio
fall short of phr. v.	*“Last year we fell short of the target by two points.”* Not reach a goal. ficar aquém, não atingir
sweet spot n.	*“Sixty to seventy percent is Google’s sweet spot.”* The best range: not too easy, not too hard. ponto ideal
turn things around expr.	*“Companies in trouble try to turn things around with big goals.”* Change a bad situation into a good one. reverter uma situação ruim
psychological safety n.	*“Psychological safety means you can say ‘this will not work’.”* The belief that you will not be punished for a mistake or a question. segurança psicológica

Match the chunk

Write the letter of the meaning on the line.

EXAMPLE **on track**

Making the progress you planned.

Find the meaning in the box. In your exercise, write its letter on the line.

A The best range: not too easy, not too hard.	**B** A goal set just beyond what seems possible.
C The belief that you will not be punished for a mistake or a question.	**D** Agreement and support from the people who must do the work.
E Change a bad situation into a good one.	**F** Not reach a goal.

1 **stretch goal** _____

2 **buy-in** _____

3 **fall short of** _____

4 **sweet spot** _____

5 **turn things around** _____

6 **psychological safety** _____

Pick the chunk

Circle the words that complete the sentence. Each answer is a chunk, not a single word.

EXAMPLE My manager wants me _____ a short update every Friday.

to write

Family 1: want + person + to + verb. The to belongs to the pattern.

1 A goal set just beyond what seems possible is called a _____ goal.

○ stress ○ stretch ○ strength

2 We need everyone's _____ before we announce the new target.

○ buying ○ buy-out ○ buy-in

3 I expect the team _____ the target by Friday.

○ to meet ○ meeting ○ meet

4 If we _____ short of the goal, I want to hear about it early.

○ go ○ fall ○ get

5 Let the team _____ its own deadline.

○ choose ○ choosing ○ to choose

6 I recommend that every manager _____ the target with the team.

○ share ○ to share ○ shares

7 I'd like you _____ afraid to tell me that something is not working.

○ don't be ○ not to be ○ not be

8 The director challenged us _____ sales by next year.

○ double ○ doubling ○ to double

Write the missing word

Write one word in the space. Use the pattern from the lesson. The verb in brackets is the one you need.

EXAMPLE The coach had everyone **say** the plan out loud. (say)
Have + person + verb, with no to. The verb stays in the base form.

1 I'd like you _____ aim higher this year.

2 My manager let us _____ our own targets. (set)

3 I suggest that she _____ the goal with the team. (share)

4 I asked them _____ to wait for permission.

5 A good leader makes people _____ that their work matters. (feel)

6 A score of 60 to 70 percent is the sweet _____.

Where does the not go?

Read the situation. Circle the sentence that says it.

EXAMPLE You never asked Ana to stay late. She stayed because she wanted to.
I didn't ask Ana to stay late.
You made no request, so the not goes to the first verb: didn't ask.

1 You told the team: "Please do not send the draft yet."
- ○ I didn't ask the team to send the draft yet.
- ○ I asked the team not to send the draft yet.

2 The director said no: nobody could leave early.
- ○ The director didn't let us leave early.
- ○ The director let us not leave early.

3 Nobody ever told Rui to change the plan. He did it alone.
- ○ I told Rui not to change the plan.
- ○ I didn't tell Rui to change the plan.

4 You recommend, in a formal email, that Carla take on no more projects.
- ○ I suggest that she no take on more projects.
- ○ I suggest her not to take on more projects.
- ○ I suggest that she not take on more projects.

5 LISTEN

The sentence you will say tomorrow

Three short moments from a meeting. Open the lesson on the screen, go to section 5 and press play.
The numbers match.

What did you hear?

Listen as many times as you like. Then circle your answer.

EXAMPLE **You hear:** "I expect the team to aim high this quarter. But if we reach seventy percent of the goal, I will still call that a good result."
What will the speaker call a good result?
Reaching seventy percent of the goal
Listen for the last sentence.

1 ▶ What does the manager ask each team to do?

○ Propose its own target ○ Follow last year's number ○ Wait for the director

2 ▶ What does the speaker suggest?

○ Work fewer weekends ○ Choose an easier goal ○ Celebrate each step

3 ▶ What does the director want from the team?

○ To work more hours ○ To hear about problems early ○ To lower the goal

6 BOSS?

Can you say it at a meeting?

Read each sentence a manager might say. Circle the blue thumb if you can say it at a meeting. Circle the pink thumb if it is too much.

		I CAN SAY IT AT A MEETING	TOO MUCH
1	"I'd like us to **raise the bar** this quarter."		
2	"Stop being **lazy** and hit the number."		
3	"Failure is not an option."		
4	"I don't care how you do it. Just get it done."		
5	"I expect you to push back if you think the goal is wrong."		
6	"I suggest that we review the target every month."		
7	"Let's make this a stretch goal, not a promise."		
8	"Anyone who doesn't like the goal can leave."		
9	"You're not paid to **complain**."		

7 THE CASE

Set the goal in five moves

Say why it matters. Give a specific, difficult target. Show that you believe in the team. Make bad news safe. Say how you will score it.

1 SAY WHY IT MATTERS

Here is why this matters: our clients wait two days for an answer, and some of them leave.

Start with the reason, not with the number.

2 GIVE A SPECIFIC, DIFFICULT TARGET

I'd like us to cut the response time from 48 hours to 24 by the end of the year.

A number and a date. "Do your best" is not a target.

3	**SHOW THAT YOU BELIEVE IN THE TEAM**	**This is a stretch, and I expect you to find ways that I have not thought of.** Belief is part of the message. Say it.
4	**MAKE BAD NEWS SAFE**	**I want you to tell me early if we are falling behind. Nobody will be blamed for bad news.** Say what will happen when someone brings a problem.
5	**SAY HOW YOU WILL SCORE IT**	**Reaching 70% will count as a strong result, and we will review it together every month.** Say what success and a miss look like.

Too blunt, say this

Write a better version of each sentence on the line.

1 Just work harder.

_____

2 I don't want to hear **excuses**.

_____

3 You have no ambition.

_____

4 **Failure is not an option**.

_____

5 If you **miss** it, **it's on you**.

_____

YOUR TURN · THE CASE

Choose one goal for a team you lead or know. Make your case in five moves, out loud, in under one minute.

_____

_____

_____

8 **THE ANSWER**

When the team says it cannot be done

Do not argue. Hear the worry, limit the claim, ask what it would take, and offer something real.

1	**HEAR THE WORRY**	**I hear you, and it is a big step.** Say what you understand before you say what you want.
2	**LIMIT THE CLAIM**	**That may be true for the full year. Let's start with the first three months.** A claim about "always" is almost always wrong.
3	**ASK WHAT IT WOULD TAKE**	**What would it take to get there?** A calm question works better than a speech.
4	**OFFER SOMETHING REAL**	**I can't add people, but I can take the weekly report off your plate.** A small, true offer is better than a big promise.

5 SET A CHECKPOINT

Let's review it in four weeks and adjust if we need to.

People accept a hard goal more easily when it has a review date.

A real exchange

ANALYST	Forty percent more? That is not realistic. Last year we missed by thirty.
MANAGER	I hear you, and it is a big jump. What would it take to get there?
ANALYST	Two more people, or fewer reports.
MANAGER	Fair point. I can't add people, but I can take the weekly report off your plate. Can we review it in four weeks?

When the director pushes back

DIRECTOR	If the team is not a little afraid, it will not **push**.
MANAGER	I see your point, but Google's study of 180 teams **ranked** psychological safety first of five. What does the evidence say about fear?

YOUR TURN · ANALYST

The analyst says: "This goal is not realistic. Last year we missed by 30%." Answer in three moves: hear the worry, ask what it would take, set a checkpoint.

YOUR TURN · DIRECTOR

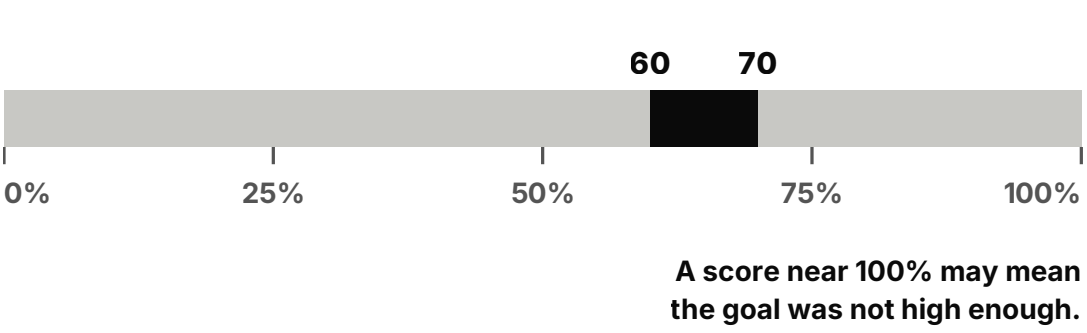
The director says: "Nobody works hard when they feel safe." Answer in three moves: agree with what you can, limit the claim, ask for the evidence.

9 OTHER SIDE

How the team hears it

Your team does not read your plan. It listens for answers to a few questions: why this goal, does my boss believe I can do it, what happens if I miss. Here is the evidence behind each question and the words you can use.

Google's scale for an ambitious objective



Each objective is scored from 0 to 1, shown here as 0 to 100%. The score is the share of the objective the team reached: 100% means all of it. Google re:Work, Set goals with OKRs.

Numbers you can quote

35 years	of research on goal setting: specific, difficult goals **consistently** led to higher performance than telling people to **do their best**. Locke and Latham, American Psychologist, 2002
180 teams	studied by Google. **Psychological safety** came first of five dynamics. Google re:Work, Understand team effectiveness
60 to 70%	is Google's **sweet spot** for the average score of ambitious objectives. Google re:Work, Set goals with OKRs
87 sources	in a **review** of leadership styles: **transformational leadership** was linked to better **outcomes**, and **hands-off** leadership to worse ones. Judge and Piccolo, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2004
17 studies	in a **review** of the Pygmalion effect in management, with 2,874 people. The effect was strong on average and **varied** a lot between **settings**. McNatt, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2000
About 70%	of the **difference** in engagement between teams comes from the manager, according to Gallup. Gallup, 2026 (the page does not give the sample)
Almost 50,000 leaders	were **rated** by about half a million colleagues. Inspiring others was the skill that most separated effective leaders from average ones. Zenger Folkman, a consultancy, company data

What the team asks, and what the evidence says

LEVER	THE TEAM ASKS	THE EVIDENCE
Meaning	"Why this goal?"	**Commitment** grows when leaders communicate an inspiring vision and **behave supportively**. Locke and Latham, 2002.
Belief	"Does my boss think I can do it?"	Managers' expectations were linked to performance in a **review** of 17 studies. The effect **varied** a lot. McNatt, 2000.
Target	"What exactly, and by when?"	Specific, difficult goals led to higher performance than "do your best". Locke and Latham, 2002.
Safety	"What happens if I miss?"	Psychological safety came first of five dynamics in Google's study of 180 teams.
Dose	"How many goals, and how hard?"	Companies in trouble adopt stretch goals and nearly always fail. Sitkin, Miller and See, Harvard Business Review, 2017. Goals should be **prescribed** in doses.
Fairness	"Who gets the big projects, and who gets the credit?"	Stretch assignments did not **benefit** every group **equally**. Gilmartin and others, Harvard Business Review, 2025.

Six terms and the sentence for the meeting

TERM	IN THE MEETING
stretch goal n.	"Let's treat this as a stretch goal: 70% will count as a strong result."

buy-in n.	“I want your buy-in before I take this to the director.”
commitment n.	“A hard goal only works if the team has real commitment to it.”
psychological safety n.	“Psychological safety means you can say ‘this will not work’ in this room.”
accountability n.	“Accountability is not blame: we all know who **owns** what.”
milestone n.	“Let’s set a milestone for each month, so we can see progress.”

YOUR TURN · BUILD A FILE

Choose one lever. Write a three-line file: the lever, one fact with its source, and one sentence you could say to your team.

10 **NOW, AGAIN**

Did the dossier move you?

Same four sentences. Look back at page 1. Did you move?

A good leader sets targets that feel a little uncomfortable.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

Telling people to “do your best” works as well as giving them a number.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A team that feels safe works less hard.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A leader who expects more usually gets more.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

Facts come from Locke and Latham (2002), Judge and Piccolo (2004), McNatt (2000), Google re:Work, Harvard Business Review (Livingston, Galinsky, Folkman, Amabile and Kramer, Sitkin, Miller and See, Gilmartin and others), the Goals Gone Wild review, Gallup, Zenger Folkman and the John F. Kennedy Presidential Library. The phrases, the numbers in the examples (48 and 24 hours, 40%) and the sample answers are written for this lesson. The comments are fictional.